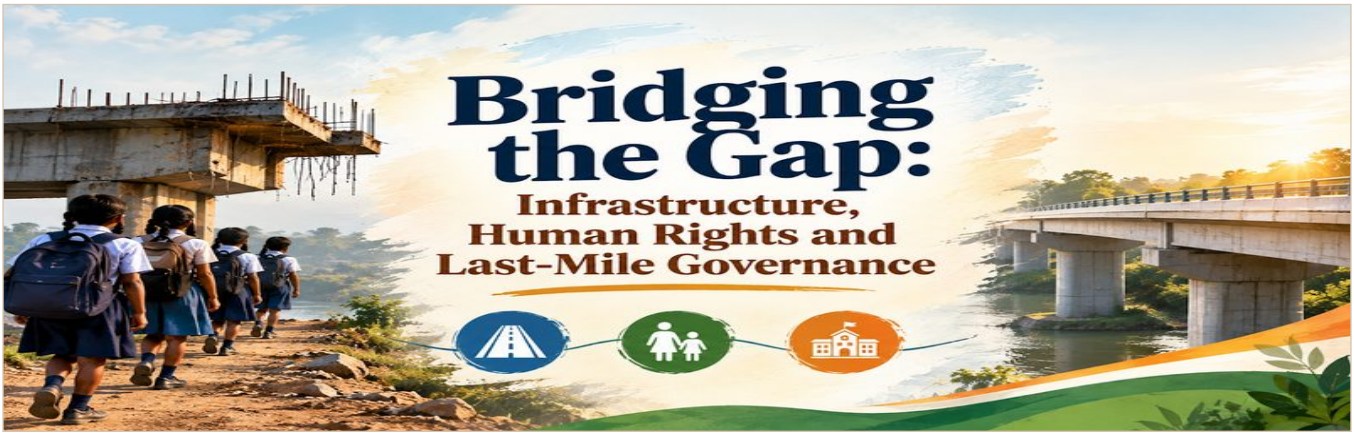


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[GS-II: GOVERNANCE, HUMAN RIGHTS, CHILD RIGHTS, RIGHT TO EDUCATION, ACCOUNTABILITY • GS-III: INFRASTRUCTURE]
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"Bridging the Gap: Infrastructure, Human Rights and Last-Mile Governance"



This article highlights the NHRC's intervention over school children risking their lives to cross an unfinished bridge, exposing critical gaps in infrastructure and last-mile governance. It examines issues of human rights, child safety, access to education, and accountability in public infrastructure development

"Bridging the Gap: Infrastructure, Human Rights and Last-Mile Governance"

Syllabus areas:

GS-II: Governance, Human Rights, Child Rights, Right to Education, Accountability

GS-III: Infrastructure, Project Implementation , Safety

Why in news?

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), India has taken *suo motu* cognizance of a media report that dozens of children from Khambhatha and nearby settlements in the Mainpur Block area of Gariyaband district in Chhattisgarh, are compelled to climb a narrow and slippery iron ladder, attached to an unfinished bridge, to cross the Paiririver to reach their schools. Reportedly, the monsoon turns the shallow river into a torrent.

The Commission has observed that the contents of the media report, if true, raise serious issues of violation of human rights. Therefore, it has issued a notice to the Chief Secretary, Government of Chhattisgarh, calling for a detailed report on the matter within two weeks.

According to the media report, carried on 3rd September 2026, a roughly 300-metre-long bridge between Deharguda and Khambhatha in Mainpur Block has been under construction for nearly six years despite the villagers having been assured of its completion in six months by the concerned authorities about a year ago.

A Case of Basic Infrastructure Failure

- School children being forced to cross a river through an unfinished bridge.
- Bridge under construction for nearly six years.
- Risks to children's **life, safety, education and dignity**.
- Disconnect between infrastructure expenditure and actual service delivery.

What is NHRC?

The **National Human Rights Commission** is a statutory body established under the Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993. It is mandated to protect and promote human rights.

However, the NHRC's recommendations are generally **recommendatory rather than equivalent to binding judicial orders**. Ultimately, effective remedial action depends upon responsible administration and implementation by the concerned authorities.

Infrastructure as a Human Rights Enabler

Infrastructure is often viewed primarily from an economic perspective. However, its social and rights-based dimensions are equally important. A bridge can connect villages to schools, hospitals, markets and government institutions. Its absence can isolate communities and restrict access to essential services.

In the Gariyaband case, the unfinished bridge is not simply an example of delayed public works. If children are compelled to undertake a dangerous journey to reach school, the infrastructure deficit directly affects their ability to exercise basic rights.

This demonstrates an important principle of governance: **the availability of a public service does not necessarily mean that people have meaningful access to it**.

Child Rights Perspective

Children are among the most vulnerable sections of society and require special protection from avoidable risks.

When children have to cross a river using an unfinished or unsafe structure, their physical safety is placed at risk. Such circumstances can also affect school attendance and educational continuity.

The principle of the **best interests of the child** should therefore guide public policy decisions affecting children's access to education and essential services.

Infrastructure projects near schools or along frequently used routes should incorporate **child-safety considerations** during planning, construction and monitoring.

Governance and Administrative Accountability

A major concern arising from the incident is the prolonged delay in completing the bridge.

Public infrastructure projects can face delays because of several factors, including:

- Poor project planning
- Contractual disputes
- Funding constraints
- Land or statutory issues
- Weak project monitoring
- Administrative coordination failures
- Contractor-related problems
- Lack of timely corrective action

The precise reasons in this particular case need to be established through the official inquiry.

Nevertheless, the broader governance lesson is clear: **accountability should not end with sanctioning a project**. Authorities must ensure timely execution, quality control, safety and eventual functionality.

Education Requires More Than Schools

The incident also highlights the need to look beyond school enrolment when assessing educational outcomes.

A functional education system requires:

- Accessible schools
- Safe roads and bridges
- Transportation facilities where necessary

- Electricity and digital connectivity
- Drinking water and sanitation
- Adequate teachers and learning resources

Thus, education policy must be supported by infrastructure and connectivity policies.

This calls for greater **convergence among departments** dealing with education, rural development, roads, public works and disaster management.

Way Forward

Several measures can address such infrastructure and governance gaps:

1. Immediate safety arrangements: A safe temporary route should be provided until the permanent bridge is completed.

2. Time-bound completion: Delayed projects should have clearly defined milestones and periodic review mechanisms.

3. Strong project monitoring: Technology such as geo-tagging, digital dashboards and milestone-based monitoring can improve transparency.

4. Fixing responsibility: Where avoidable administrative or contractual failures are established, appropriate accountability should follow.

5. Child-centred planning: Infrastructure projects affecting children's mobility should include specific safety assessments.

6. Community participation: Local communities can play an important role in monitoring public works and reporting deficiencies.

7. Inter-departmental coordination: Education, infrastructure, rural development and disaster-management authorities should coordinate wherever infrastructure affects access to essential services.

8. Outcome-based evaluation: Projects should ultimately be assessed on whether they provide safe, accessible and reliable public services.





